1398 CE . Under him, the scholar-officials, steeped in conservative Confucian ideology, returned to head the bureaucracy. The emperor shared their prejudice towards foreign trade and the merchant class. While such trade continued, it was subject to unpredictable prohibitions. Early in his reign, the first Ming emperor, Hong Wu, introduced the ‘Haijin’ policy, or the prohibition on private maritime trade. This continued to be enforced till its formal lifting in 1567 when the ‘Kaihai’ or open seas policy was adopted. However, the Haijin policy was never implemented with strictness in practice and eventually proved to be counter-productive and had to be revoked. When Hongwu died in 1398, his successor Jiawen reigned only for four years before being ousted by his uncle Yongle in 1402. Jiawen was rumoured to have escaped either into an area still held by the Mongols or to a South-East Asian country. The sense of insecurity this created and the search for political legitimacy seemed to have led Yongle to execute several grand projects, such as the construction of a new capital at Beijing, the repair and extension of the Great Wall and the launch of Chinese naval armadas under Zheng He.

Another major project undertaken during his rule was the extension and broadening of the Grand Canal which connected the capital of Beijing with the port town of Yangzhou in the southern province of Jiangsu. The Grand Canal has its origins in ancient China, but its main role was to provide a north–south inland waterway to transport grain from the south to the north, in particular to the capital. It was, to begin with, more a series of interconnected canals linking various rivers and lakes. It was during the Sui dynasty (581–619 CE) that major construction was carried out and the canal took shape as a continuous waterway. Yongle extended and expanded the canal, in part to carry the large-sized timber columns that he needed for the grand palace, the Forbidden City, which he constructed in the capital, Beijing. These originally came from the forests of Sichuan.

The revival of foreign trade, which had been reduced due to prohibitions under the Hongwu emperor, was an objective during Yongle’s rule. A Yongle edict says:

> Now all within the four seas are one family! Let there be mutual trade at the frontier barriers in